

No More Excuses, DOCTOR

The 78-member Cabinet brings out the struggle within the Congress. Now Team Manmohan has to deliver.

By Priya Sahgal

In the end, it was an anticlimax. It took 11 days and two oath-taking ceremonies for the Prime Minister to finally get his act together, even after the Congress won its largest mandate in nearly two decades. The ministerial team of 78 is a blend of experience and expertise but it also has a sympathy quota for those who cannot be wished away, however hard Manmohan Singh may have tried. As the good Doctor himself said recently, this was a mandate that would brook no excuses. With only four allies to accommodate, his present Cabinet has the largest number of Congressmen than ever before. (Out of the 33 Cabinet ministers, 27 are Congressmen and six of the seven ministers of state with independent charge are also from the ruling party). With so many party colleagues to assist him, the Prime Minister can no longer blame the bad boys from the allies. He has to deliver.

There was indeed an embarrassment of riches with as many as 206 Lok Sabha and 70 Rajya Sabha MPs from the Congress. As it turned out, the allies were much easier to placate than the Prime Minister's own colleagues in the Congress. Apart from caste and regional considerations, he also had to contend with over-sized egos. For over a week, 13 Cabinet

grandees had to wait, all dressed up and no office to go.

Even a small state like Himachal Pradesh that sends only 4 Lok Sabha MPs was not without its ironies. During the first round, Anand Sharma, a Rajya Sabha member from the state was sworn in. This angered former chief minister Virbhadra Singh who is the lone Congress Lok Sabha MP from Himachal. The Raja of Mandi is an old hand at playing the pressure game. He rounded up his followers to demand his induction and announced before the television cameras that "I am ready to move to the Centre." Sonia Gandhi and Manmohan caved in and a beaming Virbhadra took oath during the second round. Along with this little tantrum came an anomaly. While Himachal has two Cabinet ministers, inexplicably the three states that sent

THE PRIME MINISTER WASTED 11 PRECIOUS DAYS TO FINALISE HIS TEAM AND THE DELAY TOOK SOME OF THE SHEEN OUT OF THE VICTORY. IT IS A CLEAN CABINET BUT IT COULD HAVE BEEN LEANER.



the bulk of MPs have not been adequately represented. Between them, Andhra Pradesh, Rajasthan and Uttar Pradesh have 74 MPs, yet Andhra and Rajasthan have only one Cabinet berth each while Uttar Pradesh, the state where the Congress crafted its most famous comeback story in E-2009, does not have a single Cabinet minister. Even a small state like Kerala boasts of two Cabinet ministers and four ministers of state.

Uttar Pradesh state elections are slated for 2012 and this will be Rahul Gandhi's next big test. This is also one reason why he opted to stay out of the Government, preferring to work on the revival he has begun in the state. However, what has sent the right message is that turncoats who joined the